

CLASS NO BAR

Bhopal, Madhya Pradesh

SARVA SHIKSHA ABHIYAN

Budget allocation for 2008-09

Rs 13,100 crore

DISTINCTION

PASS

FAIL

Her hair pleated neatly, a playful Tulsi looks every bit a regular school goer in her starched uniform. Just a year ago, she had followed her parents into rag-picking. Hers is one of the biggest success stories of the Sarva Shiksha Abhiyan (SSA) that aims to provide elementary education to all children between the ages of 6 and 14 by 2010. "Tulsi was in rags, barefoot and had lice in her hair before we persuaded her to join school," says Nagendra Pandey, the teacher in charge of the residential bridge course launched under the SSA at Deepshikha School in TT Nagar, Bhopal. Tulsi and 40 others will go to Class V next year if they do well in the bridge course. Launched in 2000-2001, the SSA merged together all the elementary school education schemes. It continues as the flagship school education programme of the central government. A study by NGO Pratham, released this year, shows that enrollment is up in the state and so is the teachers' average attendance and



By PANKAJ TIWARI

WRITE STUFF: A class in progress at Deepshikha School in Bhopal

pupil-teacher ratio. Reading and mathematical abilities have also improved. Yet there have been some setbacks. The attendance of students of Classes I-VIII is down from what it was in 2005. The enrolment for girls in the 15-16 age group, too, has fallen behind the national average.

by Ambresh Mishra

CARROT WORKS

Agara, Karnataka

MIDDAY MEAL SCHEME

Budget allocation for 2008-09

Rs 8,000 crore

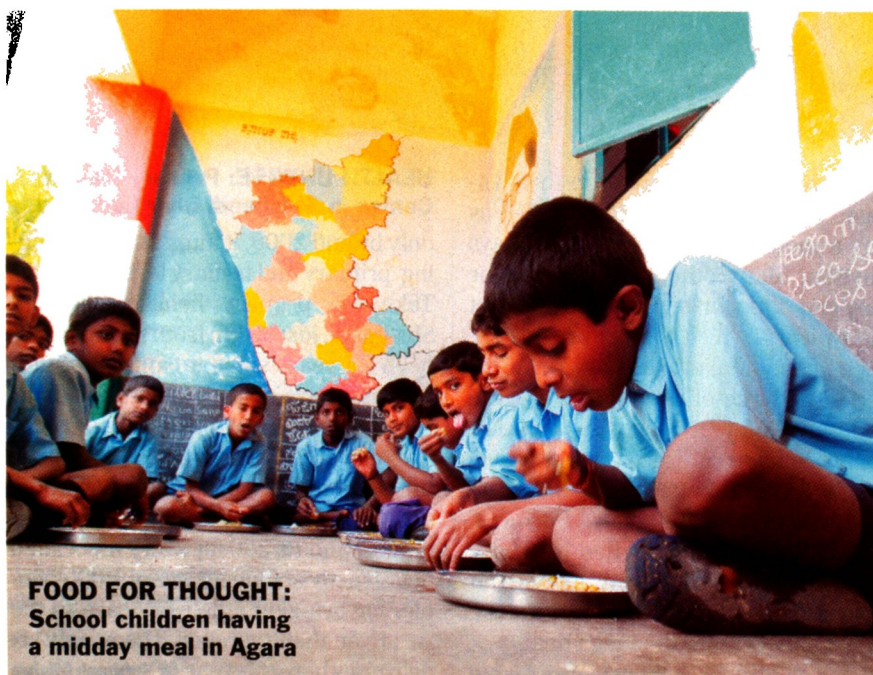
DISTINCTION

PASS

FAIL

Sahara, seven, is a farmhand's son in village Agara near Bangalore. His parents decided to send him to school only when they discovered that the Government's primary and high school was serving hot cooked meals daily to students. Sahara is one of the 70.5 lakh children who get free lunch as part of the Midday Meal Scheme that began in 2002 and covers students from Class I to X in government and government-aided schools in Karnataka. In just one year, the number of school students in Agara doubled, says headmaster R.K. Gopal. Children from Classes I to VII are served a 175g meal, which includes 100g rice, 20g pulses, oil and salt and 55g of vegetable, while high school students are given a 255g meal. From 65, the student strength, mostly from nearby villages, has doubled to 130.

by Stephen David



FOOD FOR THOUGHT: School children having a midday meal in Agara

GIRISH GV